

NOTES ON THE STRASSBURG GOSPEL FRAGMENTS.

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It is a remarkable fact that, of the various texts by which the literature of the early Church has, during the past two generations, been enriched, not one of first-rate importance has become known to us through the medium of the Coptic language. It would not be unnatural to expect, from Egypt's early conversion and heroic devotion to Christianity, that the vulgar tongue would have preserved something beyond those remnants of Gnosticism which, for the theologian and perhaps for the philologist as well, constitute to-day the most remarkable documents of Coptic literature.

Although its editor declines to see in the newly found text the survival of a Gnostic work, there can be at any rate no doubt that it belonged to none of the documents which the Catholic Church has been concerned to preserve. Dr. Carl Schmidt was the first to recognize, among the collection of miscellaneous papyrus fragments acquired last year by the Strassburg University, the importance of those which Dr. Jacoby, with the help of Professor Spiegelberg, has just edited, and he pronounced them to be a part of some uncanonical Gospel. Dr. Jacoby, who is responsible for the elaborate theological commentary with which the edition is provided, is inclined to recognize in the text, a work whose recovery, even to so limited an extent, would be of the greatest interest—the Gospel *κατ' Αἰγυπτίους*. Of the value of Dr. Jacoby's reasons for the proposed identification I am not competent to judge. These reasons are shortly: (1) the *primâ facie* probability of an unidentified Gospel, found in Egypt and long enough popular there to be still extant in a Coptic translation at a relatively late period, being that once current under the name of the Egyptians' Gospel; (2) synoptic features in parts of the new fragment such as were—to judge from its extant remains—probably characteristic of the Egyptians' Gospel also; (3) at the same time, evidence of an acquaintance with the

Johannine theology, likewise demonstrable for the Egyptians' Gospel; (4) a Christology, however, still more developed than that of St. John and comparable with that to be discerned in the Egyptians' Gospel, to which (following Harnack) the editor also reckons the Oxyrhynchus *Logia*, where he sees a like stage of development represented; (5) the incidental usage of the word "mystery," which is compared to Epiphanius' employment of the word *μυστηριωδῶς* in reference to the Egyptians' Gospel.

Whether these arguments will suffice to convince theologians of the proposed identification remains to be seen. Should they do so, it will, according to Dr. Jacoby, become necessary to revise the chronological position of the Egyptians' Gospel, placed by Harnack not later than 130, and consequently the relation of that to St. John's Gospel, of which, Dr. Jacoby holds, it either borrowed or to which, as the earlier composition, it supplied certain ideas.

It is further important to observe that, like certain other extra-canonical works of this class, notably the Gospel of Peter, the narrative appears to be put here into the mouths of the Apostles themselves ("we").

The following are the contents of the texts, so far as can be ascertained in their very fragmentary condition. The leaf numbered "Kopt. 5" shows (1) part of a prayer addressed by Christ to His Father, to be placed, according to Dr. Jacoby, shortly before the Passion and compared by him with John xvii; (2) a conversation, narrated by the Apostles, between them and Christ, in which He foretells His approaching fate and—what is very remarkable—uses apparently of Himself the words applied in Mat. xxvi, 41 ("the spirit is willing etc.") to the disciples.

"Kopt. 6" appears to contain (1) a continuation of this conversation, wherein Christ refers to the revelations of His power already granted to His apostles. The name, Mary, occurs here, apparently addressed by Christ. (2) In Dr. Jacoby's opinion a fragment from an account of the Ascension. Of the smaller pieces too little is legible to allow of even a guess at the subjects of which they treat.

The MS. itself, of which three considerable and eleven very small fragments have been recognized and pieced together, is provisionally ascribed by the editors, who are well aware of the caution still needed in any attempt to date the earlier Coptic uncials, to the 5th or 6th century. The letters *ⲁ*, *ⲗ* and *ⲱ* are made each in a

single stroke;  and  are curved. Initial letters do not appear to be in any way distinguished. These features, combined in one MS., recall the Vienna Psalter (Rainer *Führer*, 1892, Taf. IV), which Professor Krall would date in the 6th century, but which might well be placed 100 years earlier. The Psalter is however written by a hand far less skilled and conventionalized than that of the Strassburg MS. There may therefore seem ground for assigning the latter to the period proposed by its editors, though two at least of the *data* on which they support their opinion—the form $\chi\epsilon\kappa\alpha\alpha\epsilon$ and the dot on the right of χ —are not unfamiliar to later texts, *e.g.* certain ostraca belonging most probably to the 7th century.

The condition of even the best of the leaves is so fragmentary that, of the fifty-six lines of which anything beyond a few letters is visible, only four are quite complete, while of the remainder some show about a half, others about two-thirds of their original total of letters. Hence it is clear that the initial task of the editor—or rather, of Professor Spiegelberg, who is here chiefly responsible—was one of reconstruction. The difficulties of such work are in this case unusually increased by the peculiarly irregular spacing of the letters, the number of which in each line appears to have differed considerably.

Great uncertainty will probably remain as to the original contents of many of the countless *lacunae*, and I have only a few alternatives to suggest here for the ingenious proposals of the editors, whose knowledge of Coptic as well as of the theological probabilities has been severely taxed.

“Kopt. 5,” *recto*, l. 1. If the phrase were a quotation of Mat. vii, 14 or 20, one would rather expect $\epsilon\beta\omicron\lambda\ \epsilon\pi$; if not, there is no need to supply $\kappa\alpha\rho\pi\omicron\varsigma$ with which $[\alpha]\epsilon\epsilon\epsilon\epsilon\epsilon$ accords (as Professor Spiegelberg has seen) so badly. Yet by reading $[\tau]\epsilon\epsilon\epsilon\epsilon\epsilon$, the only other word which seems possible, we are not much helped.

L. 8. There seems in the photograph space for $[\epsilon\pi\kappa\omicron\varsigma\epsilon]$ OC. L. 13 certainly suggests $[\alpha\iota]$, but the gap may have held a third letter.

L. 12. Instead of $\epsilon\iota\pi\epsilon$, we might read $\epsilon\iota\epsilon\epsilon$, “they (*i.e.* the worldlings) knew them not,” instead of “were not like them.” This seems at least as probable in the context.

L. 16. I think $\sigma\tau\omega\sigma\varsigma$ (or rather $\sigma\tau\omicron\sigma\varsigma$) more probable here than $\sigma\tau\omega\psi\varsigma$; cf. for instance 2 Tim. i, 10 (= Boh. $\kappa\omega\rho\varsigma$), and 1 Cor. xv, 26, with which latter passage indeed one is tempted to read $[\pi\rho\lambda\epsilon\ \delta\epsilon\ \pi]\chi\lambda\chi\epsilon\ \epsilon\psi\pi\lambda\omicron\tau\omicron\sigma\varsigma$ etc. "By whom shall the last enemy be destroyed?"

L. 18. $\overline{\chi\rho}$ is of course merely a slip for $\overline{\chi\varsigma}$, the only abbreviation used in Sa'idic.

Ib. A point on which the editor lays stress is the occurrence here of the expression $\pi\epsilon\iota\delta\ \epsilon\pi\epsilon\omicron\tau$. This he translates "the claw of Death," comparing it with the $\delta\upsilon\nu\chi\ \tau\omicron\upsilon\theta\ \chi\acute{\alpha}\rho\omicron\nu\tau\omicron\varsigma$ in a curious magical (Christian) invocation in a Gizeh papyrus. This papyrus, which Dr. Jacoby also prints with a commentary, is assigned by Grenfell to the 4th or 5th century, and in it Dr. Jacoby sees a direct quotation from his new Gospel fragments. But is it not possible here to explain the phrase sufficiently by another reference to 1 Cor. xv? For the $\kappa\acute{\epsilon}\nu\tau\rho\omicron\nu\ \tau\omicron\upsilon\theta\ \theta\alpha\nu\acute{\alpha}\tau\omicron\upsilon$ in vv. 55, 56, there is unluckily no Sa'idic version preserved; nor is the parallel Hosea xiii, 14 extant in that dialect, while in both places the Bohairic uses $\sigma\tau\tau\rho\iota$. But in the ancient Achmimic version of Hosea $\kappa\acute{\epsilon}\nu\tau\rho\omicron\nu$ is rendered (as Professor Krall kindly informs me) by $\epsilon\iota\delta$; so too in the Sa'id. Apoc. ix, 10 (*ed.* Goussen). That allows at least of the possibility that Sa'id. 1 Cor. xv, 55, 56 likewise used $\epsilon\iota\delta$ for $\kappa\acute{\epsilon}\nu\tau\rho\omicron\nu$, and if we therefore regard the present passage as simply based on that, there remains no reason for connecting it with the "claw of Charon." *

L. 19. $\beta\omega\lambda\ \epsilon\beta\omicron\lambda$, supplied by the editor, is supported by such passages as Acts ii, 24.

* $\epsilon\iota\delta$ or $\epsilon\iota\epsilon\iota\delta$ in Apoc. iv, 8 is puzzling. The Sa'idic of the passage (*ed.* Goussen) has "And the 4 beasts had each of them 6 wings in their $\epsilon\iota\epsilon\iota\delta$ round about, being full of eyes within," while later MSS. (*ed.* Amélineau and Clédat) read "from (starting from) their $\epsilon\iota\delta$." With this last the Boh. agrees, translating $\text{والواحد الواحد منهم يحيط بهم من اظافيرهم الى داخلهم}$. The only other version showing this curious reading seems to be the Syriac of Lord Crawford's MS. (*ed.* Gwynn), where $\epsilon\iota\delta = \text{ܥܝܕܐ}$. A superficial examination does not appear to show other remarkable resemblances between the Sa'id. and this Syriac text. The Ethiopic, whence some help might have been looked for, avoids the difficulty by reading merely "six wings and these all full of eyes." (So at any rate the nine MSS. of the Brit. Mus.)

"Kopt. 5," *verso*.

L. 5. Even allowing for the frequent license of scribes in omitting a repeated letter, $\pi\tau\omicron\omicron\tau\eta\tau\tau\pi$ for $\pi\tau\omicron\omicron\tau\tau\eta\tau\tau\pi$ is unlikely. And yet the photograph shows little space to spare.

L. 11. The editors are aware of the improbability of the $[\pi\omicron\sigma\pi]\epsilon\sigma$ they propose. The extant letters seem indeed too few to warrant at present any suggestions.

Ll. 12, 13. What justifies the insertion of $\tau\acute{\epsilon}\lambda\omicron\varsigma$? It scarcely seems suitable with the following $\xi\omega\omega\pi$. Nor does the interrogative $\omicron\tau\pi\epsilon$, at the end of its sentence, seem admissible. $\omicron\tau$ might perhaps be the article introducing a predicative clause.

L. 16. $\beta\omega\lambda\epsilon\beta\omicron\lambda$ in an intransitive sense would, to say the least, be very unusual.

Ll. 21, 22. Dr. C. Schmidt points out to me that this is a quotation of John xv, 20 (*v. text* in *A.Z.*, 1886, 108). The alternative τ suggested in l. 21 must of course be adopted.

"Kopt. 6," *recto*.

L. 3. The gap seems more likely to hold $[\tau\pi]$ than $[\varsigma]$, and would thus give "all your power."

Verso, l. 5. Would not $\tau\epsilon[\pi\alpha\pi\tau\alpha\pi\omicron\varsigma]\tau\omicron\lambda\omicron\varsigma$, "our apostleship," be more suitable than "His"?